

Tense at the top: Oscar Piastri (in pic) now sits ahead of his teammate Lando Norris with a cushion of nine points.

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His attempt to catch Max Verstappen last year was always a long shot, but when he did come remotely close, a single, error-filled race brought an end to his ambitious dream.

Now, however, his 21-year-old peer has closed in, showing the composure and confidence to conquer. Norris fought through the pack from sixth to finish third in Bahrain, but Piastri was completely out of sight at the front.

He crossed the line a mighty 15 seconds ahead of George Russell, who commandeered his Mercedes to second.

It was McLaren's first-ever victory in Bahrain — at its 'second home Grand Prix' — with Piastri even completing the prized hat-trick of pole, fastest lap, and victory.

Heading the right way

The F3 and F2 champion, a calm but intense driver, is only three years into the job but has caught the attention of the paddock for his sheer talent.

Many say that he emulates his mentor and manager, Mark Webber, a former F1 driver and fellow countryman. Webber's experience of battling a teammate — Sebastian Vettel back in 2010 — for the championship has certainly reaped benefits.

Piastri needed a push after his home Grand Prix. A late error — sliding into the grass at the rain-hit Albert Park track — cost him a potential win and podium. "I've only got myself to blame," said a dejected Piastri, who managed to rescue two points from the outing.

However, since then, he has outdone his teammate every step of the way. His ability to produce a clean race and extract the most from his strong McLaren has helped him surpass Norris with relative ease.

That the latter has been error-prone and once again playing

catch-up has come to Piastri's aid.

Steering clear in Saudi

With only a three-point gap heading into Saudi Arabia a week later, it was the perfect opportunity for Piastri to prove his prowess.

An extremely tight qualifying session saw Verstappen edge his closest opponent Piastri by a hundredth of a second. Norris, though, was nowhere near, after an incident in the final session cost him dearly, forcing him to start 10th.

All the Australian needed was the perfect start — and he seemed to have done exactly that, getting ahead of pole-sitter Verstappen into Turn 1. A bit of scuffle meant the Dutchman went off track to retain his lead — a move that has stirred controversy numerous times.

Often ruled a 'racing incident' or one that required a penalty and a position reversal, the controversial decision went the papaya team's way. Piastri was in front of the pack and ensured he crossed the line the same way.

An unimpressed Verstappen chose to shun his inner critic while talking about the move and settled for a strong second. Meanwhile, Charles Leclerc steered his Ferrari to third — his first podium of the season.

With another 25 points in his bag, Piastri now sits ahead of his teammate Norris with a cushion of nine points. The latter is confident of making up the deficit in no time — 19 races remain, and it's safe to say the thrilling battle has only just begun.

Siblings on the charge

Three wins in four races — Marc Marquez has taken the path of domination right from the start of the MotoGP 2025 championship.

Thailand and Argentina witnessed a commanding display by the multiple-time champion. But he was dealt a minor hiccup when he crashed in the Grand Prix of the Americas, losing out to his Ducati teammate Francesco Bagnaia.

With Qatar hosting Round 4, the Spaniard was quick to shake off the jitters and return to winning ways — once again climbing to the top step for both the sprint and main race.

He beat his brother Alex Marquez on Saturday while leading his teammate to the finish line in the Qatar GP. The brothers are atop the standings, with the elder Marquez ahead by 17 points.

Meanwhile, defending champion Jorge Martin was finally fit enough to kickstart his title defence after a long injury layoff. Having had to sit out for three races, the Aprilia rider was raring to go before an accident during the race resulted in a couple of rib fractures and a collapsed lung, ruling him out for a while. Martin is expected to miss his home race in Spain, while fellow countryman Marquez will hope to continue his impressive form.

Family affair: Marc Marquez and his younger brother Alex are atop the MotoGP standings, with the former ahead by 17 points. GETTY IMAGES

